



Power BI Viewer

User Guide

Everything you need to view, present, and keep an eye on your Power BI reports — in one fast desktop app.

For version 2.1.9

Windows & macOS

No Power BI experience required

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SECTION 1

Welcome

Power BI Viewer is a simple desktop app for one job: opening the Power BI reports and dashboards that have been shared with you — without the clutter of a web browser.

With it you can:

- **Open reports and dashboards** from any workspace you have access to, and from published Power BI Apps.
- **See how fresh the data is** at all times — every report shows when its data was last refreshed, and tells you the moment newer data is published.
- **Check the health of your data** on the Insights board: which refreshes succeeded, which failed, and for how long something has been down.
- **Run unattended slideshows** on TVs and wall displays, with automatic recovery if anything goes wrong.
- **Export what you see to PDF** in two clicks.

You sign in once with your normal Microsoft work account, and the app only ever shows you content you already have permission to see. Nothing in this guide requires any technical knowledge.

SECTION 2

Install & sign in

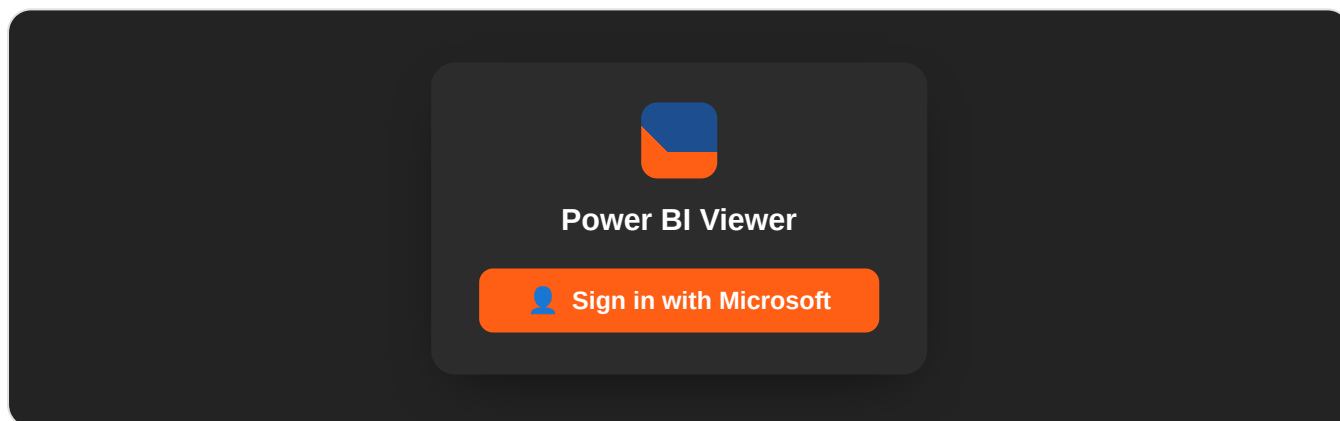
Installing on Windows

1. Run the installer you were given (a file named like `PowerBI-Viewer-2.1.9-Windows-Setup.exe`).
2. Windows may show a blue “**Windows protected your PC**” (SmartScreen) screen. This is expected for a privately distributed app — it simply means Microsoft hasn’t seen this particular installer before. Click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.
3. Follow the installer; the app starts automatically when it finishes.

Installing on macOS

1. Open the `.dmg` you were given and drag **Power BI Viewer** into **Applications**.
2. The first time you open it, right-click the app and choose **Open** if macOS warns about an unidentified developer.

Signing in — once



The sign-in screen. One button — your normal Microsoft work account.

1. Click **Sign in with Microsoft**.
2. A Microsoft sign-in window opens. Enter your work email and password (and your usual two-factor prompt, if your organization uses one).
3. That’s it. The app remembers you: the next time you open it, it signs you in automatically and goes straight to your content.

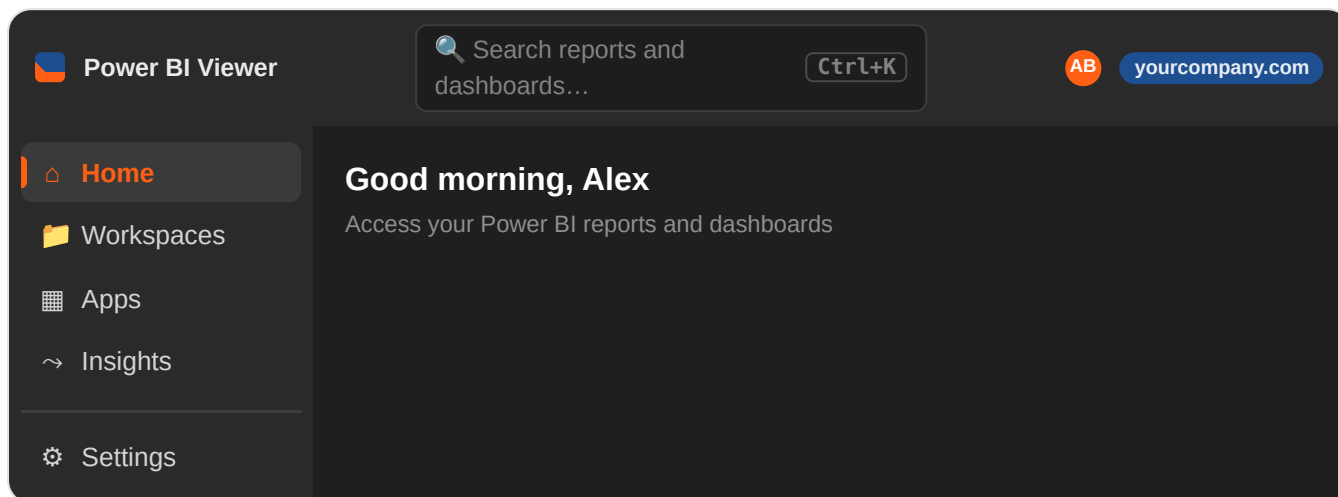
GOOD TO KNOW

You stay signed in until you choose **Sign out** yourself. If your organization ever expires the session, the app will tell you plainly — “*Your session expired. Please sign in again.*” — and one click signs you back in.

SECTION 3

Finding your way

The app has three permanent landmarks: the title bar across the top, the sidebar down the left, and the page you're viewing.



The main window: title bar with search and your account; sidebar with the five pages.

- **Title bar** — the search box (or **Ctrl** + **K**) and, on the right, your avatar with your organization's domain chip. Click the avatar for account options.
- **Sidebar** — **Home**, **Workspaces**, **Apps**, **Insights**, and **Settings** at the bottom. The top button collapses the sidebar to icons; hover an icon to see its name.
- **While viewing a report** — a toolbar appears across the top with Back, the report name, data-freshness stamps, and action buttons (covered in Section 8).

SECTION 4

Home

Home greets you by name and gets you back to the things you actually use.

- **Featured Workspaces** — quick cards for your first few workspaces. Clicking one takes you to the Workspaces page.
- **Browse Workspaces** — the big orange button; the full catalog of everything you can open.
- **Frequent** — the reports and dashboards you open most, as large tiles.
- **Recent** — everything you've opened lately, most recent first.

Frequent and Recent build up as you use the app, so on a brand-new install Home shows a short welcome with your signed-in email instead. Open a few reports and it fills in. The **Refresh** button at the top-right reloads these lists.

TIP

Tiles on Home offer a one-click *presentation mode* option — handy when you want a report full-screen for a meeting without any clicking around. See Section 10.

SECTION 5

Workspaces

Workspaces are the folders your organization publishes content into — each typically belongs to one client or team. This page lists every workspace you can see.

▶  Northwind Trading

▼  Acme Retail 3 items

 Monthly Sales Report

 Executive Overview Dashboard

 Inventory Detail Report

▼  Fabrikam Logistics

 Could not load dashboards for this workspace. Retry

 Fleet Status Report

Workspaces expand in place. If part of one fails to load, a warning bar with a **Retry** button appears for just that workspace.

- **Click a workspace** to expand it and see its reports and dashboards; click again to collapse. An item count appears once it's loaded.
- **Click any item** to open it. Reports carry a blue *Report* badge; dashboards a green *Dashboard* badge.
- **Refresh** (top-right) re-reads the whole workspace list — use it if something was just published for you.

If a workspace doesn't load

Loading can partially fail — for example, the reports arrive but the dashboards don't. The app never hides this:

- *"Could not load reports for this workspace."* or *"...dashboards..."* — the half that did load is still shown; click **Retry** to fetch the missing half.
- *"Could not load this workspace. Check your connection or your permissions."* — nothing could be read. **Retry** tries the whole workspace again. A workspace that failed to load will never silently pretend to be empty.

Retry only re-fetches that one workspace — everything else you've already loaded stays put.

SECTION 6

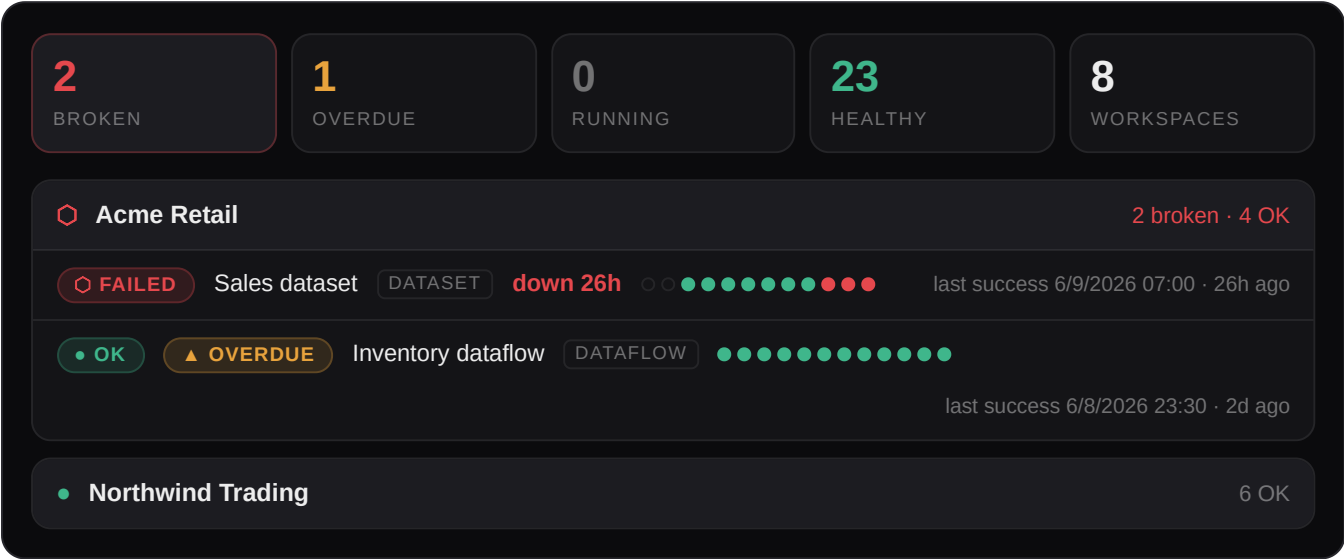
Power BI Apps

An App is a curated, packaged collection of reports that someone publishes to you — a polished front door, rather than a folder of files.

- The **Apps** page shows a card for each App published to you, with who published it and when it was last updated. Click **Open** (or anywhere on the card).
- The App opens inside the viewer with its own navigation, exactly as its publisher designed it. Use **Back to Apps** in the toolbar to leave.
- The toolbar shows the same data-freshness stamps as reports. If an App contains several reports built on different datasets, the stamp is labelled “**Oldest data**” — a single honest worst-case figure, since the app can’t know which report you’re looking at inside the App.
- If no Apps appear, none have been published to your account yet — that’s normal for many users.

Insights

Insights is the data-health board: every client workspace on one dark screen — what’s refreshing, what’s broken, for how long, and who has access. It only ever shows what *your* account is allowed to see.



The Insights board (illustrative): summary tiles, then clients grouped worst-first. Troubled clients start opened; quiet ones stay folded.

The summary tiles

TILE	WHAT IT COUNTS
Broken	Datasets and dataflows whose last refresh failed or was cancelled . Red, and impossible to miss when above zero.
Overdue	Items that have a refresh schedule turned on but no recent successful refresh — quietly late even though nothing has visibly “failed”.
Running	Refreshes happening right now.
Healthy	Items whose last refresh completed successfully.
Workspaces	How many client workspaces the board is watching for you.

The client health board

Below the tiles, every dataset and dataflow is grouped by **workspace** — i.e. by **client**. Groups with problems sort to the top and start expanded; all-quiet groups stay collapsed behind a one-line summary like “2 broken · 1 overdue · 14 OK”. Each group header

carries the symbol of its *worst* item, so a single red mark on a folded group still tells you to look inside.

What the status labels mean

STATUS	MEANING
	The last refresh completed successfully.
	The last refresh failed. The row shows how long it has been down, and the Power BI error code when one is available.
	The last refresh was cancelled before it finished.
	This item has never been refreshed.
	A refresh is in progress right now.
	This item doesn't use scheduled refresh — it reads its data live, so there is no refresh to monitor. Quiet by design.
	An extra chip on any item whose schedule is on but which has no recent successful refresh.

Status is always shown as *shape + color + word*, never color alone — so it stays readable for everyone.

“Down for” and the dot strips

- **down 26h** — how long since this item last succeeded. If it has *never* succeeded, it reads “**down — never succeeded**”. This is the number to quote when telling a client how long their data has been stale.
- **The 12 dots** — the item's last 12 refresh runs, oldest on the left, newest on the right. Green = succeeded, red = failed, hollow = no history yet. A red caption like “*3 of last 12 runs failed*” appears when any run failed — red scattered among green means an unreliable refresh, not a one-off.
- Each row also shows the **last success time**, what **triggered** the last refresh (Scheduled, Manual, or Power Automate / API), and who configured it.

Who has access & your usage

- **Who has access** — expand any workspace to see its members and their roles. People who reach content only through a published App are not in this list (Microsoft restricts App audience lists to tenant admins — see the admin view below).
- **You open most / Never opened by you** — what this app has recorded for your account on this computer: your top items, and items you can see but have never opened.

The board is a snapshot — its header shows when it was taken and whether it came from cache. Click **Refresh** for a fresh read. If some workspaces couldn't be fully read, a banner names them so you know the board may be incomplete.

FOR THE OWNER — UNLOCK ADMIN VIEW

At the bottom of Insights, Fabric administrators can click **Unlock admin view** to add tenant-wide extras: who opened what across *all* users (last 2 days to start), and the audience of each published App.

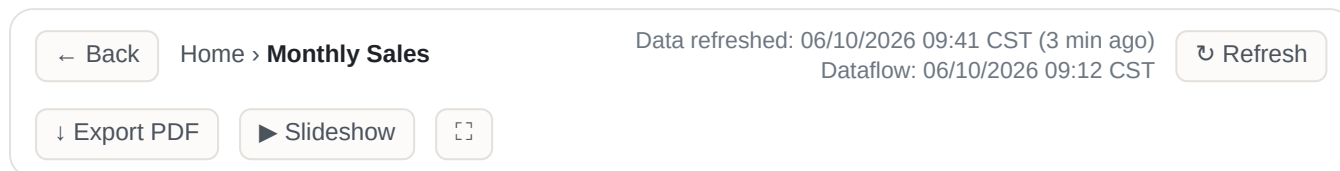
First unlock only: a Microsoft permission window appears. It can open *behind* the app window — if nothing seems to happen, check your taskbar. Approve it once (you can tick "consent on behalf of your organization") and it never asks again.

While it loads, the app reports progress honestly — "Opening Microsoft consent...", then "Reading App audiences...", then "Crunching activity log — large tenants can take a couple minutes...". A **Cancel** button is always available; cancelling simply stops waiting and changes nothing. If your account isn't a Fabric administrator, the app says so plainly and the rest of the board is unaffected.

SECTION 8

Reports & dashboards

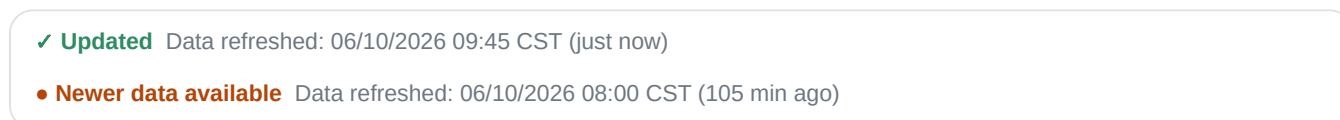
Open any item and it fills the window, topped by a single toolbar that answers the question that matters most: *how current is what I'm looking at?*



The viewer toolbar: breadcrumb on the left, freshness strip and actions on the right.

The freshness strip

- **Data refreshed** — when this report's dataset last refreshed, with a live "(N min ago)" age. Shows "—" for a moment after opening, until the first check completes.
- **Dataflow** — when the upstream data *source* last completed successfully. This is the independent "the data is genuinely current" signal: a dataset can refresh "successfully" on top of stale source data, and this line catches that.
- **△ amber stamp** — that timestamp is more than a day old.



The two freshness signals: a green "✓ Updated" flash after a refresh completes (left), and the "● Newer data available" notice when new data is published (right).

- **✓ Updated** — flashes green for a few seconds whenever a refresh actually completes and the screen repaints. It's your proof the refresh really happened.
- **● Newer data available** — the dataset has refreshed *since* this screen loaded. Click **Refresh** to bring the visuals up to date.

Automatic refresh

With **Auto-refresh reports** turned on in Settings (it is by default), you'll rarely see the "newer data" notice at all: the moment the app detects a newer dataset refresh, it re-pulls the report *in place* — your current page, filters, and slicer choices are preserved — and flashes **✓ Updated**. With it off, the notice appears and refreshing is up to you.

Toolbar actions

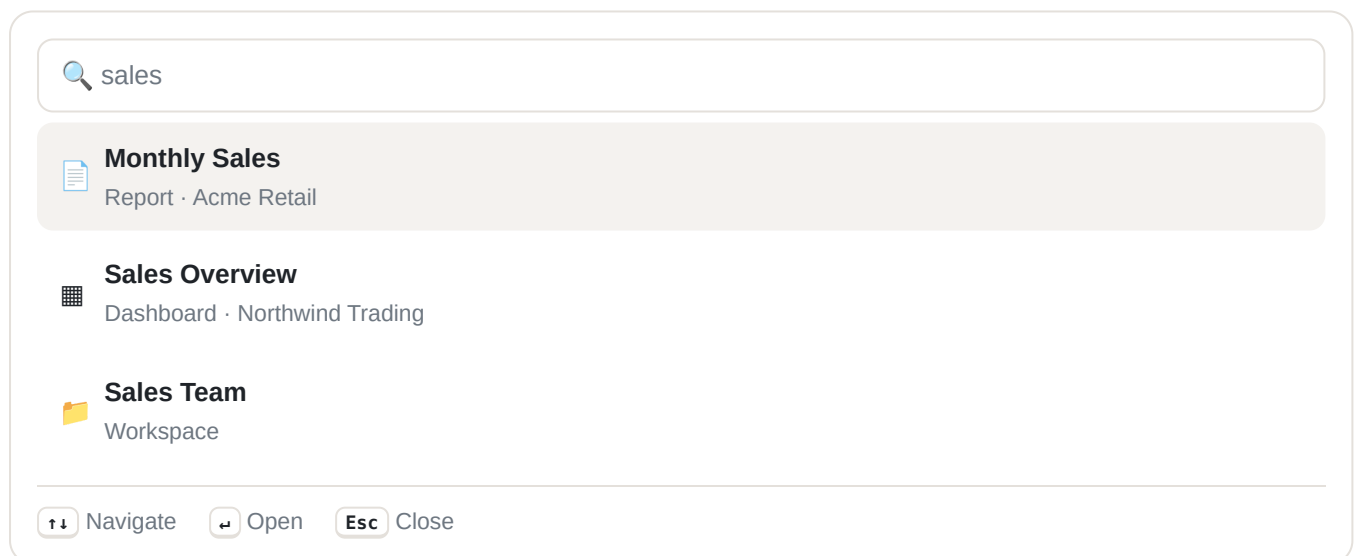
BUTTON	WHAT IT DOES
Refresh	Re-pulls the data behind the visuals, keeping your page and filters. (Power BI ignores refreshes made within ~15 seconds of each other — if nothing happens, wait a moment and try again.)
Export PDF	Saves the current view as a PDF — see Section 11.
Slideshow	Reports only: starts presentation mode — see Section 10.
Full screen	Fills the display with the report. In full screen,  /  change report pages; press  to leave.

Dashboards work the same way, with one difference: a dashboard combines tiles from several datasets, so its stamp is labelled “**Oldest data**” — the most pessimistic (and therefore most honest) figure across all of them.

SECTION 9

Search

The fastest way to anything: press  +  (or click the search box in the title bar) and start typing.



Search covers reports, dashboards, Apps, and workspaces, and is entirely keyboard-drivable.

- Results appear as you type, across **reports, dashboards, Apps, and workspaces**, each labelled with its type and workspace.
-  /  move the highlight,  opens it,  closes the dialog.
- Choosing a **workspace** result jumps to the Workspaces page with that workspace already expanded.
- If part of your catalog couldn't be read, a small warning appears above the results — what you see is still real, just possibly incomplete.

SECTION 10

Slideshow & wall displays

Slideshow turns any report into a full-screen, auto-advancing presentation — for a meeting room screen or an unattended TV that runs all day.

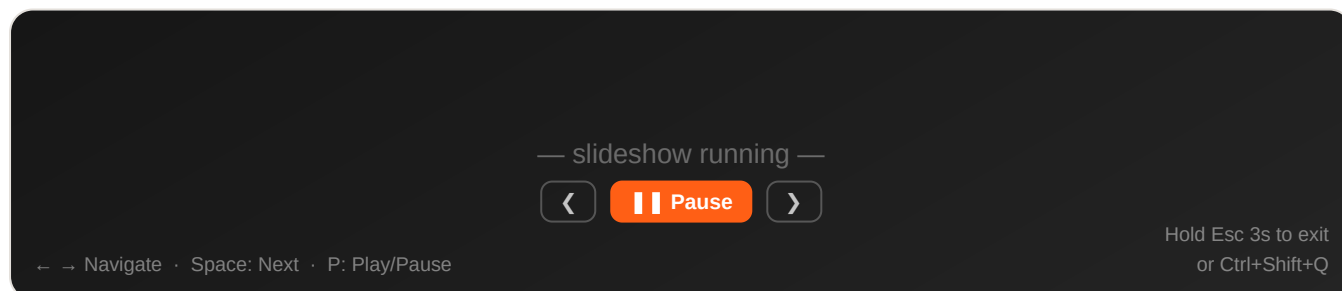
Starting and driving a slideshow

- Open a report and click **Slideshow** in the toolbar (or use a Home tile's presentation option).
- The report goes full screen and steps through its pages — and, if you choose in Settings, its bookmarks — at your chosen pace (5 seconds to 5 minutes per slide).
- Move the mouse to reveal the controls: **Play/Pause**, previous/next, a slide counter, and a small settings popover for adjusting the pace on the spot. The controls fade away after a few seconds; the screen stays clean.
- Keyboard: **→** or **Space** next slide, **←** previous, **P** play/pause, **Esc** exit.

Unattended wall displays (kiosk)

For a display that should run forever, turn on **Auto-start slideshow** in Settings (and optionally Launch on Startup so the machine boots straight into a report). In this mode the app takes care of itself:

- **The display is kept awake** — no screensaver, no sleep, for as long as the slideshow runs.
- **It heals itself.** If the embedded report ever errors out, the slideshow automatically reloads it — retrying after 5, then 30, then 60 seconds until it recovers.
- **Data stays current** using the auto-refresh interval from Settings.



In kiosk mode a small permanent hint in the bottom-right corner always shows the exit gesture — it never fades.

The exit gesture

In an auto-started (kiosk) slideshow, a stray tap of **Esc** from a curious passer-by must *not* kill the display — so a single press does nothing. To exit deliberately:

- Hold **Esc** for 3 seconds, or
- press **Ctrl** + **Shift** + **Q** for an immediate exit.

In a slideshow you started by hand, a single **Esc** exits as you'd expect. (If the slideshow settings popover is open, **Esc** closes that first.)

SECTION 11

Export to PDF

1. Click **Export PDF** in the viewer toolbar.
 2. Choose where to save. The app suggests your **Downloads** folder with a timestamped name like `powerbi-export-2026-06-10.pdf`.
 3. Wait a moment — the button reads *Exporting...* — then **“Exported to PDF”** confirms in the toolbar.
- **Reports** are exported through Power BI's own export service whenever your subscription supports it, capturing the exact page you're on *with your current filters and slicer selections applied*. If that service isn't available on your plan, the app automatically falls back to a clean snapshot of the current view with the side panes hidden — you don't have to do anything different.
 - **Dashboards and Apps** export as a crisp snapshot of what's on screen.
 - Cancelling the save dialog simply shows “Export cancelled” — nothing is written.

SECTION 12

Your account

Click your avatar at the top-right of the window. The colored chip beside it shows which organization you're signed in to — useful if you work across more than one.

- **Your name and email** — confirms who is signed in.
- **Switch account** — signs you out and immediately opens Microsoft's account picker, so you can move to a different account in one step.
- **Sign out** — asks you to confirm, then returns to the sign-in screen. You'll stay signed out until you sign in again.

SHARED COMPUTERS

If several people use the same machine, see the *Usage History* setting in Section 13 — it can clear the Recent/Frequent lists automatically at sign-out.

SECTION 13

Settings

Everything configurable lives on one page. Changes apply immediately — there is no Save button to forget.

SECTION	WHAT YOU CAN DO
Account	See your name and email; sign out.
Appearance	Theme: Light , Dark , or System (follow the operating system). Applies instantly. The Insights board stays dark by design regardless of theme.
Slideshow	Auto-advance interval (5 s – 5 min); slideshow mode — <i>Pages only</i> , <i>Bookmarks only</i> , or <i>Pages and bookmarks</i> ; Auto-start slideshow for kiosk displays (see Section 10).
Launch on Startup	What the app opens when it launches: the home screen, a specific report (picked from your recent and frequent reports), or a specific App. Pair with auto-start slideshow for a boot-to-wall-display machine.
Data Refresh	Auto-refresh reports on/off, and the refresh interval (1 min – 2 h). The interval applies to slideshow/kiosk auto-refresh; ordinary report viewing refreshes automatically the moment new data is published, regardless of the interval.
Usage History	When to clear your Recent/Frequent lists on sign-out: <i>Never</i> , <i>Always</i> , or <i>On shared machine</i> . Plus a Clear usage history now button.
Reset	Put every setting back to its default.
About	Your app version, and Open user guide — which opens this very document in your browser.

SECTION 14

App updates

Windows — automatic and invisible

- The app checks for updates in the background every couple of hours and downloads them quietly. The download never touches the running app, so it can't break anything.
- **Updates install silently the next time you close or restart the app.** No pop-ups, no “update now?” nagging — you simply find yourself on the new version next launch.
- **Critical fixes** can be marked as required. In that rare case the app shows “*A required update is ready*” and restarts itself about 30 seconds later — including on unattended wall displays, so every machine is fixed within minutes without anyone touching it.

macOS — notify only

- The Mac app checks at launch and, if a newer version exists, offers a **Download** button. Updating is manual: download, then replace the app in Applications. The app never modifies itself.

SECTION 15

Keyboard shortcuts

KEYS	ACTION
Ctrl + K (⌘K on Mac)	Open search — works anywhere once signed in
↑ / ↓ · Enter · Esc	In search: move highlight · open · close
← / →	Report in full screen: previous / next report page
→ or Space	Slideshow: next slide
←	Slideshow: previous slide
P	Slideshow: play / pause
Esc	Slideshow you started by hand: exit (closes the settings popover first if open)
Esc held 3 s	Kiosk / auto-started slideshow: exit
Ctrl + Shift + Q	Kiosk / auto-started slideshow: exit immediately

Troubleshooting

“This is taking too long to load. Check your connection and try again.”

A report waited about 45 seconds without loading. Usually a network hiccup — click **Try again**. If it persists, check your internet connection; on office networks, a proxy or VPN can also block the Power BI service (the App viewer says so explicitly when that's the likely cause).

“Could not load this workspace. Check your connection or your permissions.”

Click **Retry** in the warning bar — it re-fetches just that workspace. If it keeps failing while others load fine, your access to that workspace may have been removed; ask whoever manages your Power BI access.

“This report could not be loaded. You may not have access, or it may have been removed.”

The item was deleted or your permission changed. Tiles for removed items disappear from your Home lists automatically once detected.

Sign-in problems

- “Your session expired. Please sign in again.” — normal after a long absence or an organization-wide policy change. Just sign in again.
- **Nothing happens after clicking Sign in** — the Microsoft window may have opened behind the app. Check your taskbar / Dock.
- **Signed in as the wrong account?** Use **Switch account** in the avatar menu — it always shows the account picker.

The data looks old

Read the freshness strip (Section 8): if *Data refreshed* is recent but *Dataflow* is old, the report refreshed on top of stale source data — the problem is upstream, and the Insights board will show you exactly which dataset or dataflow is down and for how long.

If support asks for log files

The app keeps a small diagnostic log (no report data, no passwords). Find it here and attach `main.log`:

- **Windows:** `%APPDATA%\Power BI Viewer\logs` — paste that into the File Explorer address bar.
- **macOS:** `~/Library/Logs/Power BI Viewer`

This guide is bundled with the app — open it any time from **Settings** → **About** → **Open user guide**.